

Stark Choice for Trump as Growing War Enters Third Week



A couple in the ruins of their apartment in Tehran. President Trump has wrestled publicly with his options for the Iran war, in which more than 2,100 people have died.

Risks in Either a Longer Fight or a Pullback

This article is by David E. Sanger, Eric Schmitt, Tyler Pager, Ronen Bergman and Julian E. Barnes.

WASHINGTON — Two weeks into a war against Iran that he chose to launch, President Trump faces a stark choice — stay in the battle to achieve the dauntingly ambitious goals he has set, or try to extract himself from an expanding and intensifying conflict that is generating damaging military, diplomatic and economic shock waves.

He has quickly discovered that both options are deeply problematic, littered with consequences that he and his team downplayed when he plunged the United States, alongside Israel, into the biggest war in the Middle East in nearly a quarter-century.

He can continue to fight a weakened enemy that has nevertheless proved adept at extracting a fast-rising economic price for the United States and its allies, tying the global energy markets in knots and striking a dozen countries across the region.

Battling on would put more American lives at risk, accelerate the financial costs and risk further fraying alliances. There is angst within Mr. Trump's political base over the sharp departure from his pledge to avoid entangling the nation in more wars.

Or he can begin to pull back, even though most of his objectives — including assuring that Iran never again possesses the capability to produce a nuclear weapon — are not yet met. The biggest military accomplishments of the joint U.S.-Israel action so far, officials say, have been wiping out much of Iran's missile arsenal and air defenses and crippling its navy. Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the country's brutal leader for nearly 40 years, is dead.

But an emboldened theocracy is still in power, apparently commanded by the ayatollah's injured son, who has already sworn to

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STRAIT OF HORMUZ Why little was done to find an alternative for transporting oil. PAGE B1

EUROPE'S RESPONSE A show of force in the Mideast has diverted assets from other fronts. PAGE A9

By Suing G.O.P. States, Trump Is Trying to Fast-Track Policy

Disputed Legal Maneuvers Bypass Legislation

By ZACH MONTAGUE

WASHINGTON — Last June, the Trump administration hauled Texas into court, claiming that a decades-old state law once championed by Republicans violated federal law.

Within six hours, the two sides reached an agreement.

Instead of fighting, Texas immediately settled. Led by Attorney General Ken Paxton, a close ally of President Trump, Texas simply agreed the state law, which allowed undocumented high school students to pay in-state tuition at public universities, should be invalidated. The resolution eliminated any need for a slow and messy vote to overturn the statute in the State Legislature.

It was one of a string of lawsuits in which the Trump administration has reached settlements with friendly adversaries.

The strategy appears to have allowed the administration to do an end run around the legislative process and enact policies that

will affect states and, in some cases, the whole country.

The settlements have come despite Supreme Court rulings that require lawsuits to be waged between adversarial parties and a reticence among administration officials dating to Mr. Trump's first term with entering legal settlements that bind the government's hands.

In some cases, like in Texas, the legal maneuver has allowed states to quietly break free from their own laws, outside the normal legislative process. In others, it has helped the Trump administration lock in changes at the federal level that could persist for years after Mr. Trump leaves office.

In Florida, for instance, the Trump administration in February reached a legal settlement with the Republican-led state requiring the Department of Homeland Security to forgo one of its authorities to admit immigrants for

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Antagonism With Tehran Festering for Decades

By NEIL MacFARQUHAR

While President Trump has used a scattershot approach to explain the goals of his war on Iran — one day it's regime change, the next stopping an immediate nuclear threat — he has been relatively consistent in framing the conflict as the culmination of historic grievances.

“For 47 years, the Iranian regime has chanted ‘Death to America’ and waged an unending campaign of bloodshed and mass murder, targeting the United States, our troops and the innocent people in many, many countries,” Mr. Trump said in his first speech

Cycle of Confrontation Has Ensnarled String of U.S. Presidents

about the war on Feb. 28, stressing repeatedly that it was time to end the threat.

His comments fit into a long-standing narrative. No country has bedeviled the United States quite like Iran ever since the Islamic Revolution in 1979 toppled Shah Mohammed Reza Pahlavi, a brutally repressive leader who was a staunch American ally. A fundamental clash in political

agendas has repeatedly brought the two countries to the brink of war.

Iran cast the United States as the “Great Satan,” with habitual chants against America and Israel at virtually every officially sanctioned prayer gathering or demonstration. All that might seem like agitprop. But the ritual underscored that a cornerstone of the Muslim Shiite theocracy was to undermine American influence in the Middle East and beyond.

“I don't think Americans actually care that much about Iran, but Iran deeply cared about America and deeply cared about its commitment to overturning what it

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Iceland's Chief ‘Lava Cooler’ Braces for Next Volcanic Eruption

By AMELIA NIERENBERG and EGILL BJARNASON

GRINDAVÍK, Iceland — As a swarm of earthquakes and volcanic eruptions began to rip through southwestern Iceland in late 2023, a firefighter named Helgi Hjorleifsson jumped into action.

Lava was heading toward the already evacuated town of Grindavík, a power plant and the Blue Lagoon — one of Iceland's most popular tourist attractions.

Mr. Hjorleifsson was tapped to lead a team of firefighters trying to do the unimaginable: Cool the lava enough to control it.

The firefighters and other emergency responders managed to protect the power plant, the lagoon and most of the houses. But now, another eruption could be imminent. And when it comes, Mr. Hjorleifsson, 47, will be ready.

“The earth is ready to blow up,” Mr. Hjorleifsson (pronounced hyor-LAYV-son) said on a recent afternoon as he drove a Times reporter and a photographer around the eruption site in southern Iceland, where the lava field still steamed in freezing air.



The lava field from a 2021 eruption that firefighters redirected away from Grindavik, Iceland.

If and when that happens, Mr. Hjorleifsson — 6-foot-5, soft-spoken and with a strong aversion to public speaking — most likely will be back in front of cameras to explain one of Iceland's biggest crisis management

efforts in recent memory. And he would most likely face another bout of dangerous frontline work that keeps him away from his three daughters — who are 15, 17 and 22 — and his wife, an opera singer.

But he knows he has a duty: He is Iceland's only “lava cooling manager” — or “hraunkælingarstjóri” in Icelandic. “It's definitely going on my tombstone,” he joked.

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Less Cost and More Support Drive U.S. Theater to London

By MICHAEL PAULSON

LONDON — In a ramshackle onetime warehouse on the south side of London, with a leaky pitched roof, a shabby chic bar and posters of shows gone by, a group of Americans gathered this winter to make a musical about a famous American writer.

It was a small show, “Beautiful Little Fool,” about the glamorous-but-tragic marriage of F. Scott and Zelda Fitzgerald. It had an accomplished American director, American writers and an American producer, who had looked around

the United States for places to stage a first production of this show, but who chose London for a simple reason: cost.

About five miles east of the theater where “Beautiful Little Fool” was performed, another group of Americans spent the first weeks of the year in a rehearsal studio working on a much bigger musical, “The Greatest Showman,” adapted from the film about another singular American figure, the circus impresario P.T. Barnum.

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Judy Blume had a constellation of concerns about a book that Mark Oppenheimer was writing about her. PAGE C1

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The Creator of Candy Land

Eleanor Abbott invented the beloved game nearly 80 years ago as a way to distract children who were suffering in the hospital during a polio outbreak. Overlooked. PAGE A20

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Tom Rothman

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Bellwether Race in France

The vote for mayor in Marseille ended in a virtual dead heat, prompting a runoff. The result could forecast the strength of the far right. PAGE A4

